

Positive peer pressure

While negative peer pressure makes a person feel unhappy, unwell, or uncomfortable, positive peer pressure boosts a person's feelings of wellness and happiness. When individuals align themselves with positive people, the supportive atmosphere can lead to healthy choices. When friends join a club or sports team, or work hard to achieve good marks, for example, it can have a positive effect on everyone in that group.

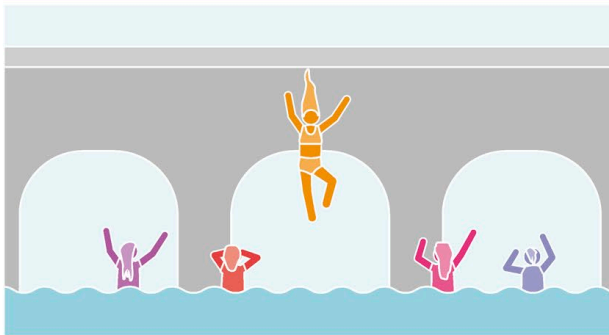


Pressure points

Teens, and adults, too, give in to peer pressure for many complex reasons, but common to most people is a desire to be liked and to fit in. They may also feel concerned that they will be made fun of if they don't participate, or are curious to try something that others are doing.

▽ Joining in

Doing what everyone else is doing can help a person feel like they fit in, but it's not worth it if the activity is dangerous.



GOOD TO KNOW

Science of peer pressure

Teens can find it difficult to control risky behavior, especially when their friends are around, or in situations that are emotionally charged. This is because the teen brain is still maturing and learning the skills to control impulsive behavior, to think ahead, and to resist pressure from others.

While teens are able to make accurate evaluations of risks when given time and space, heat-of-the-moment situations push them to pay more attention to the immediate rewards and external factors such as peer pressure, and less attention to the possible risks.

Tips for dealing with peer pressure

While joining in with friends provides people with a sense of belonging, resisting the urge to fit in can show great strength of character.

Having friends helps build self-confidence, but it's important to have self-confidence on your own terms, too, to help you resist negative peer pressure.

Don't apologize for being yourself and for standing up to peer pressure. Be clear, as uncertainty can lead to further pressure.

Be assertive, but brief and to the point. Say "no" and mean it. You might even walk away to show you won't compromise.

If you're feeling unsure, think about what the consequences will be if you give in. This will help you weigh up your possible actions.

Listen to other people's reasons before acting. Consider the different options available, rather than joining in straight away.